

Ambient Ada

A focus session is the one thing Aqademiq keeps doing while the app is closed. So the lock screen, the Island and the home screen aren't posters for the product — they are the product, running somewhere else.

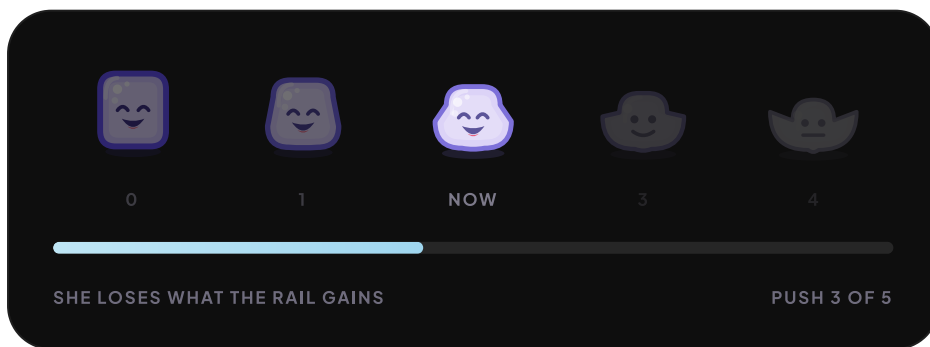
Everything on this page is one live session. Freeze her anywhere and every surface changes state at once.

1 reason to take the Island

5 pushes a session

0 pushes for the clock

3 widgets, not nine



§1 One rule, four states

Ice already means several things in Aqademiq, and on a 38-pixel-tall surface an ambiguous metaphor is just a smudge. Four states, applied everywhere, never bent.



Melting • time being spent

A running session. Nothing else in the product is allowed to melt.



Frost • time held

Pause is already called Freeze. So freezing is a change of matter, not a glyph swap.



Puddle · spent

The mood ramp's low end, and a finished session's aftermath. Never a task, never a day.



Outline · nothing happened

A day you weren't here. Absence is not depletion, so it is never drawn as a puddle.

WHAT THE RULE FORBIDS

A ticked task never melts. Melting means *time being spent*, so a melted task would read as drained rather than done — colliding head-on with the mood ramp, where a puddle is the worst day a student can have. Done keeps its circle. A metaphor that means two things means nothing.

§2 The Dynamic Island

Three presentations, one activity state. The countdown is system-rendered and free; Ada's melt stage is the only thing we ever push — five times a session, one drip each.

9:41



14:00



COMPACT · LIVE · ANOTHER APP IN FRONT

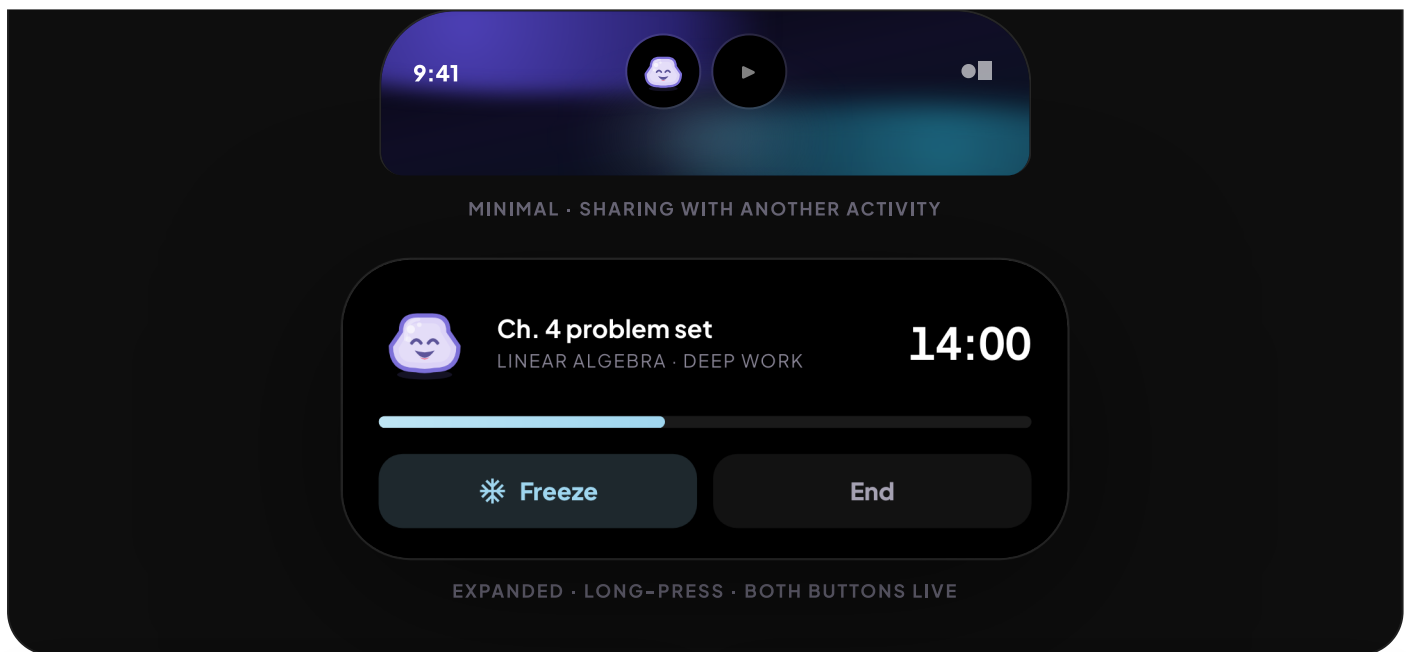
9:41



12:00



COMPACT · FROZEN · PINNED REFERENCE



COMPACT

Ada leading, clock trailing

She is the only element we update. The mono clock is the system's, ticking on its own.

MINIMAL

She is the icon

A cube silhouette is legible at 22pt where a generic glyph isn't. This is where the mascot quietly pays for itself.

EXPANDED

Intent, restored

A student who long-presses at minute forty has forgotten what they sat down to do. The title answers that.

ONE THING ONLY

The Island is scarce, shared and system-owned. Aqademiq takes it for an active focus session and nothing else — never a due task, never an Ada reply, never a streak. When no session is running, we are not there at all.

§3 The lock screen, and the puddle

More room, so the idea that can't fit in the Island lives here: the melt has to go somewhere. As Ada loses volume, a the ring closes around her as she loses volume — conservation of ice as a progress bar.

9:41



Tue 18 Aug

9:41



NEXT

Ch. 4 problem set

14:00 · Linear Algebra



AQADEMIQ · DEEP WORK

Ch. 4 problem set

14:00





LIVE ACTIVITY · LOCK SCREEN · FULLY LIVE

Freeze is a change of state, not a pause glyph

Ada stops mid-melt and crystallises: frost spurs, a cooler palette, the ring losing its gradient and going flat blue. Every other timer swaps a play glyph for a pause glyph. This one changes state of matter — and reads correctly from two metres away, across a desk.

One press, no unlock

The white circle is an interactive control: an interrupted student holds the session without finding the app, and without the session dying. The tutorial teaches *freeze, don't quit*. One press from anywhere is worth more than any animation here.

ONE HONESTY

A system countdown cannot be paused

Freezing swaps the live timer for static remaining text, then swaps back on resume — which is why the frozen clock here is frost-blue rather than white. Handled, it's invisible. Unhandled, a frozen session keeps counting down and the feature is worse than not shipping.

The ring is the rail, curled up

One number, read twice: Ada's volume and the ring closing around her. That is the whole card — no second progress bar, no percentage caption. The straight rail returns where there is room for it: the expanded Island, the Android notification, StandBy.

§4 Everywhere she has to survive

Ada exists three times over — Flutter, SwiftUI, Android — and has to hold up where there is no colour, no size and no light. All of these are drawn from one geometry, so none of them can drift.

22 PT · MINIMAL ISLAND · LIVE AND FROZEN



At 22pt the face is gone as information — the silhouette and the frost spurs carry the state.

24 DP · ANDROID STATUS-BAR MASK · ONE FLAT COLOUR



No fill, no stroke, no face — same geometry, flattened. Design this silhouette first and let it constrain the rest.

**12:00**
FROZEN

Dimmed, frost-blue collapses toward the background. Frozen has to stay distinguishable by silhouette, never by hue alone.

One Ada, three renderers

Three hand-drawn mascots drift within two releases. Generate staged vectors from the same geometry as a build step and snapshot-test all three. Never rasterise — she is the brand, and a PNG Ada will be wrong at the next display density.

What crosses the boundary

End timestamp, frozen flag, melt stage, task title, subject tint, Prism mode — a small flat object through a shared container. No models, no network, no images. The extension is never asked to think.

The clock is free; only Ada costs

Both platforms render a countdown from an end timestamp for nothing. Never push a per-second update: five stage changes carry a whole session, and each one lets a single drip fall. The constraint produces better restraint than taste would.

§5 Three widgets, each with one job

Widgets are glanced at, not operated. Most study apps ship a shrunken task list nobody reads. Three here, each answering a single question without being opened — and the gallery is where a student meets them, so it gets designed too.

9:41



Aqademiq



Focus

Start five minutes without opening anything.

FOCUS

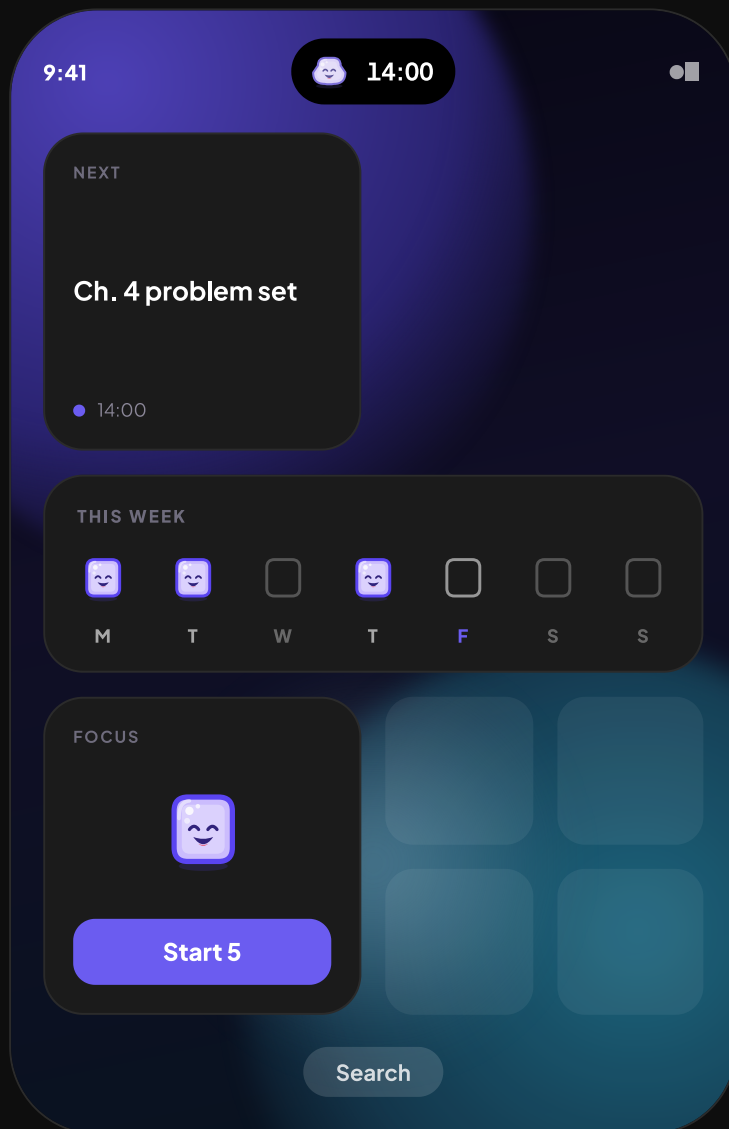


Start 5

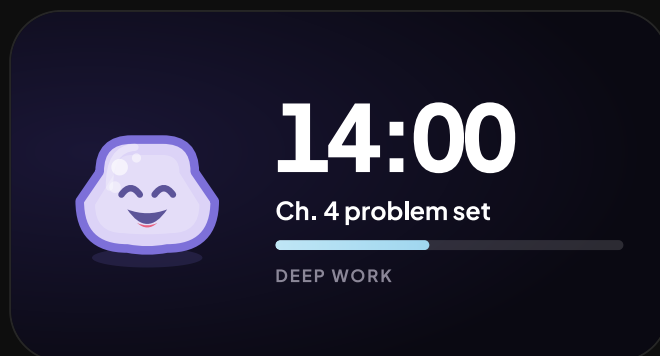


 Add widget

WIDGET GALLERY · TAP THE DOTS



HOME SCREEN · IN PLACE · SESSION STILL IN THE ISLAND



STANDBY · CHARGING, LANDSCAPE, PROPPED BESIDE YOU

Next

One task, not three. A list makes a student choose again — and choosing again is the thing that stalls them.

This week

The row the app already uses for check-ins, lifted onto the home screen: a day you logged wears Ada's face, a day you didn't is an empty outline, and today's letter is the only accent. No count, no percentage, no judgement.

Start 5

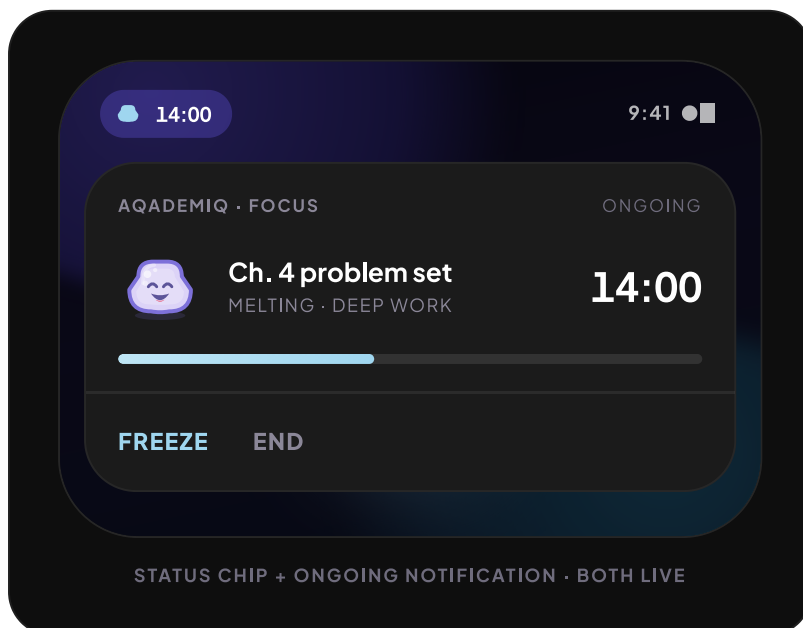
Five, not twenty-five — the lowest possible barrier between an idle thumb and a started session. Press it: the whole page starts melting.

The gallery is a first impression

Most apps let the OS show a grey placeholder here. Three named widgets, one line each, and the same Ada — the pick becomes obvious before anything is installed.

§6 Android — same idea, different physics

No Island. Instead: an ongoing notification whose chronometer the system ticks for free, and — on recent Android — a status-bar chip that behaves remarkably like the compact Island. Ship this first; it reaches the widest install base.



The floor and the ceiling, one design

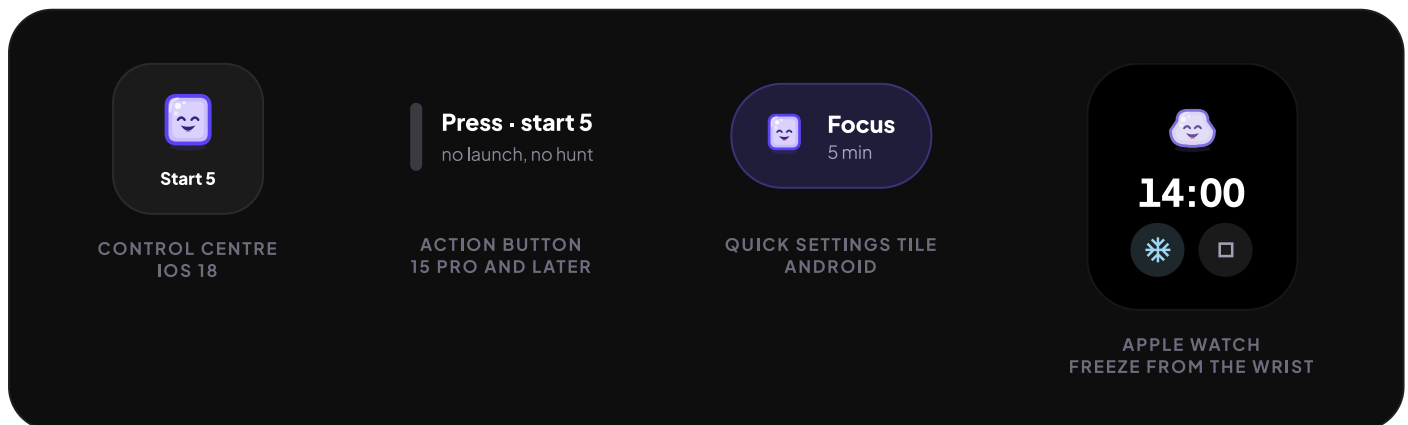
The floor is an ongoing notification: a chronometer, marked ongoing so it can't be swiped away mid-session, with Freeze and End as actions. The ceiling promotes the same notification to the lock screen and a status chip. Feature-detect and degrade — never fork the design.

THE CONSTRAINT THAT WILL BITE

Android masks status-bar icons to one flat colour. Ada's chip has to be a silhouette that survives losing every fill, stroke and face — recognisable as a cube by outline alone at 24dp. Design that first; retrofitting it is how mascots become blobs.

§7 The cheap surfaces worth taking

Small alone; together they are the difference between a good implementation and one that gets written about. All four are the same intent — start five minutes — wearing four different clothes.



§8 What Ada refuses to do out there

- 01 **Never squat in the Island.** A running session or nothing. The moment it carries a due-task reminder we are a squatter, and students remember that.
- 02 **No lock-screen guilt, ever.** No "you haven't studied today", no decaying streak, no red. The lock screen is the surface with the least consent.
- 03 **No buzz during a session.** The activity is ambient, never alerting. The promise of a focus session is that nothing interrupts it — including us.
- 04 **One button, no operable widgets.** Ticking tasks from the home screen sounds useful and produces mis-taps against stale data. Glance, then open.

05 **No Prism switching from outside.** Modes cross-fade over five adaptive seconds. That cannot be driven from a lock-screen tap without sounding broken — so we show the mode and never offer it.

06 **No melted tasks, no puddle days.** Restated, because it is the one rule someone will break for a nice-looking widget.

§9 Sequence

01 The session end instant

An absolute end timestamp plus accumulated frozen time, with Freeze pushing the end forward. Invisible inside the app; everything else is blocked on it.

02 Android ongoing notification

Cheapest real win, widest reach — and it validates the shared state object before any Swift exists.

03 Native scaffolding

Raise the iOS floor, add the widget extension, the shared container and entitlements — then the single-source Ada pipeline and its snapshot tests, before three copies exist to reconcile.

04 Live Activity · lock screen

The full card with the puddle rail and the frozen state. The Island is a smaller presentation of this same activity, so the bigger design problem comes first.

05 Dynamic Island

Compact, minimal, expanded, plus the interactive Freeze. Mostly layout once the card is right.

06 Widgets and the gallery

Next, This week, Start 5, each with its gallery copy — then the lock-screen family from the same data.

07 StandBy, Controls, Watch

Small individually. Together, the difference between a good implementation and one that gets photographed.